

Dhanurasana: The Bow Pose

A gentle guide to mastering this energising backbend



What is Dhanurasana?

Dhanurasana, or Bow Pose, is a classic backbend that strengthens your entire back while opening your chest and shoulders. The name comes from the Sanskrit word "dhanur," meaning bow, as your body resembles an archer's bow when you lift into the pose.

This asana combines strength and flexibility, making it perfect for building core stability and improving posture. It's accessible to most practitioners with proper alignment and mindful practice.



Important Precautions

Pregnancy & Menstruation

Avoid this pose during pregnancy and heavy menstrual periods. The abdominal pressure may cause discomfort.

Back & Neck Issues

Not recommended for those with recent back injuries, herniated discs, or severe neck problems. Consult your doctor first.

Blood Pressure Concerns

Those with high or low blood pressure should practice with caution or avoid this pose altogether.

Recent Surgery

Avoid if you've had recent abdominal, back, or chest surgery. Allow full recovery before attempting.

Getting Ready: Starting Position

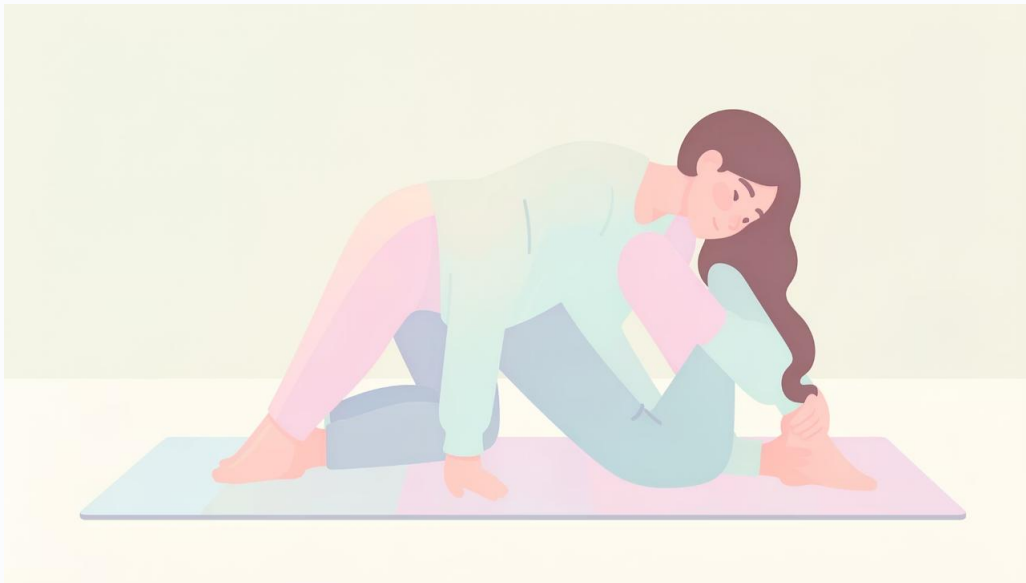
Step 1

Begin by lying face down on your yoga mat with your arms alongside your body, palms facing up. Ensure your legs are hip-width apart and your forehead rests comfortably on the mat.

Take a few deep breaths to centre yourself. Relax your shoulders away from your ears and engage your core muscles gently.



Hand Placement



Step 2

As you inhale, bend your knees and reach your hands back to grasp your ankles. Your thumbs should be on the outside of your feet.

If you can't reach your ankles yet, don't worry. Use a yoga strap around your feet or simply hold your lower legs. Progress will come with practice.

Lifting into the Bow

Step 3

Press your ankles firmly into your hands as you lift your chest and thighs off the mat simultaneously. Your body weight should now rest on your lower abdomen.

Keep your gaze forward or slightly upward, but don't strain your neck. The lift should come from your back muscles, not your arms.

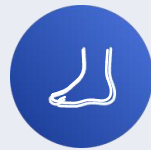


Final Alignment



Gaze

Look straight ahead or slightly up.
Keep your neck relaxed and in line
with your spine.



Feet

Press your ankles into your hands
firmly. Point your toes toward the
ceiling for full extension.



Chest

Open your chest wide and lift your
heart toward the sky. This creates the
beautiful bow shape.

Hold the pose for 20-30 seconds, breathing deeply through your nose. Feel the stretch across your entire front body.

Releasing the Pose



Step 4

Exhale slowly as you release your ankles and lower your chest, thighs, and legs back to the mat. Take a moment to rest in the starting position.

Follow with a gentle counterpose like Child's Pose or Savasana to release any tension in your back and shoulders.

Benefits of Dhanurasana



Strengthens Back Muscles

Builds strength in your entire back, improving posture and reducing back pain over time.



Stimulates Digestion

Massages abdominal organs, aiding digestion and relieving constipation when practised regularly.



Increases Flexibility

Stretches your entire front body, including hip flexors, chest, and shoulders for greater mobility.



Opens Chest & Lungs

Expands your chest cavity, improving breathing capacity and lung function with regular practice.



Improves Balance

Enhances body awareness and coordination as you balance on your lower abdomen in the pose.



Boosts Energy

Invigorates the body and mind, helping to reduce fatigue and increase mental clarity throughout your day.

Practice Mindfully

Remember that yoga is a journey, not a destination. Dhanurasana may feel challenging at first, but with consistent practice and patience, you'll notice gradual improvements in both strength and flexibility.

Key tips: Always warm up before attempting this pose, listen to your body's signals, and never force yourself into discomfort. Use props when needed and progress at your own pace.

Enjoy the process of building strength and opening your heart with this beautiful, energising asana.

